

knowledge of each other's finances, it can be easy to maintain a cash stash that their partner does not know about. These nest eggs are sometimes considered "mad money" to be used as the individual saw fit or as a "safety net" if that person needed to get away or separate from their partner.

Keeping money matters secret can cause problems, especially if one partner's actions involve unwise money moves. If the couple is married, one partner's decisions will inevitably affect the other, as Mort tragically found out.

Mort had made up his mind to acquire success both professionally, personally, and materially. He started his career as an investment adviser and at the age of twenty-five he was branch manager of a busy downtown Washington, D.C. bank. Personally he had also experienced success. Mort had married a wonderful young woman, Linda, who had attended one of Mort's investment seminars. She became pregnant shortly after their marriage and was now taking care of their two-year-old full-time.

One day, not feeling well, Mort came home from work early. Linda was not home, so when the phone rang he answered it. He was very surprised to discover it was a bill collector. At first Mort thought they must have the wrong number but he soon realized that indeed they were trying to contact his wife. "It must be a mistake," he thought. "I'm sure she'll have an explanation."

When Linda came home later that afternoon he told her about the call. Instead of confirming his conclusion that it had been a mistake, she started crying. A confession ensued where Linda admitted to having twenty credit cards. Mort was astounded since he never saw the bills or noticed an inordinate amount of purchases. She explained that she had always intercepted the bills since she could retrieve the mail before Mort came home from work. And since she was responsible for paying the household bills, Mort never knew the extent of their debt.

Linda loved to shop and often spent her days pushing their

